Case Study: Building a Group & Family Travel Planning Platform

RETHINK SYSTEMS | COHORT 7 | WEEK 7

Duration: 8 Days **Deliverables:** PRD + Working MVP **Team:** Individual (group support)
Deadline: 4th April 2026, 11:59PM

Background & Context

Over the past decade, travel has emerged as one of the largest and fastest-growing consumer categories globally. At the intersection of rising disposable incomes, digital-first booking behavior, and a cultural shift toward experience-driven spending — travel has become deeply embedded in how people socialize, celebrate, and connect.

The global travel and tourism market has grown rapidly:

- **The global travel market** was valued at approximately $1.6 trillion in 2025 and is projected to reach ~$2.5 trillion by 2033, growing at a CAGR of ~5.7%.
- **Group travel specifically** reached ~$168 billion in 2024 and is projected to grow at a CAGR of ~7.2%, reaching over $314 billion by 2033 — outpacing solo travel growth.
- **In India,** the travel and tourism market was valued at ~$22.5 billion in 2024, with domestic tourism contributing over ₹14.64 trillion to GDP in 2023 — surpassing pre-pandemic levels by 15%.
- **India recorded ~2.5 billion domestic tourist visits** in 2023, up from 1.73 billion in 2022 — a 45% year-on-year surge.

This growth has been accelerated by several structural shifts:

- **Tier II and III city travelers:** Average monthly domestic travel searches in India jumped from 103 million in 2022 to 141 million in 2024, with much of this growth driven by smaller cities.
- **Younger demographics:** Millennials and Gen Z are the primary drivers of group travel. Younger Indians often travel with friends or spouses, while older generations prefer family trips.
- **Post-pandemic experience spending:** 80% of travel service providers in India report increased travel budgets since 2022, with a quarter observing a rise of over 20%.
- **Digital booking dominance:** Over 70% of Indian corporations now use technology-led solutions for travel management. The online travel services segment in India was valued at ~$15.9 billion in 2024.

The group travel segment is the key growth story. Leisure group travel — friend groups, family vacations, reunions, and celebratory trips — remains the largest segment of the group travel market, accounting for a significant share of the $168 billion global market in 2024.

In India alone, group domestic travel has exploded. Popular group destinations like Goa, Manali, Pondicherry, Jaipur, and Kerala see millions of group bookings annually. The country's domestic travel market is projected to reach 5.2 billion trips by 2030.

However, despite the growth of booking tools, the group coordination layer remains largely unsolved.

The Group Travel Problem

When a single person books a trip, the journey is clear and well-served by existing tools — MakeMyTrip, Booking.com, Google Travel, and dozens of others handle search, compare, and book seamlessly.

But when a group of 4+ people decides to travel together, a fundamentally different problem emerges. It is no longer a booking problem. It is a coordination problem.

Group travel sits at the intersection of:

- Collective decision-making (where do we go?)
- Calendar coordination (when can everyone go?)
- Financial alignment (what can everyone afford?)
- Itinerary collaboration (what do we do each day?)
- Real-time communication (who's doing what right now?)

The current tool landscape for group trip planning is fragmented across multiple platforms:

Tool	What It Solves	What It Misses
WhatsApp Groups	Discussion, link sharing	No structure, messages get buried, polls expire, no itinerary
Google Sheets	Budget tracking, lists	No real-time collaboration feel, no mobile-first UX, intimidating for non-planners
Splitwise	Expense splitting post-trip	No trip planning, no itinerary, only useful after the trip is over
Wanderlog	Itinerary + map view, some collaboration	Weak on group voting, no budget splitting, limited offline on free tier

TripIt	Flight/hotel organization, real-time alerts	No collaborative editing, no budgeting, single-user focused
Google Travel	Inspiration, saved places	No group features at all, no shared planning
MakeMyTrip / Booking	Search and book	Individual booking only, no group coordination layer

As one travel industry review summarized: travelers today typically need Wanderlog for itineraries, Splitwise for group expenses, Google Maps for navigation, and WhatsApp for communication — four separate apps for a single trip. No product handles the full group journey end-to-end.

This creates an underserved whitespace: a product that owns the group coordination layer — from destination decision to post-trip settlement.

AI Disruption in Travel Planning

The rise of AI tools is beginning to change how both consumers and companies approach travel planning.

Many tasks that previously required hours of manual research are now partially or fully automated using AI tools.

Examples of tasks increasingly supported by AI:

- Destination research and comparison across multiple parameters
- Itinerary generation based on group size, budget, and preferences
- Real-time price tracking and deal alerts
- Automatic expense categorization and split calculations
- Translation and local recommendation engines
- Route optimization for multi-stop trips

Major platforms are already integrating AI:

- **MakeMyTrip** launched an advanced generative AI assistant in October 2024, offering hyper-personalized itinerary planning and multi-lingual support for Tier-II city travelers.
- **Wanderlog** uses AI to suggest top attractions, optimize routes, and build trips on interactive maps — features that previously required manual research across multiple sites.
- **ixigo** launched real-time fare prediction and dynamic pricing alerts using predictive analytics to help travelers time their bookings.

- **TravelPerk and TripActions** are using AI to streamline corporate group travel management, reducing booking time and policy friction.

This creates an interesting dynamic:

For products that leverage AI well

There's a chance to build a fundamentally new group planning experience. AI can serve as a "trip concierge" that:

- Suggests destinations based on group preferences, budgets, and availability
- Generates day-by-day itineraries tailored to group dynamics (kids, elders, adventure seekers)
- Handles the tedious logistics (booking windows, transit times, restaurant availability)
- Mediates group decisions by presenting tradeoffs clearly

For products that don't leverage AI

They'll compete on the same features as Google Travel, TripAdvisor, and every other itinerary app — a crowded and undifferentiated space where Wanderlog (4.9 stars on iOS, millions of users since 2019) and TripIt (established since 2012, the default for frequent travelers) already dominate.

The AI opportunity isn't just automation — it's reducing the coordination tax of group decisions. The hardest part of group travel isn't finding hotels; it's getting 6 people to agree on anything.

The Reality of Group Trip Planning

A typical group trip planning journey often looks like this:

1. Someone says "let's go somewhere" in a WhatsApp group
2. Excitement builds; 12 destinations get suggested across 3 different conversations
3. A WhatsApp poll gets created; 3 out of 7 people vote; the poll expires with no resolution
4. Dates are debated; someone can't make it; the group splinters into sub-conversations
5. Budget is never explicitly discussed; one person assumes ₹5,000/day, another assumes ₹15,000
6. One person ends up making a Google Sheet and building the itinerary alone
7. Booking happens in a rush; rooms get double-booked, trains sell out, prices spike
8. During the trip, nobody knows the plan; the organizer becomes GPS + concierge + accountant
9. Post-trip expense settling is messy; Splitwise entries are incomplete; some debts go unpaid

Unlike solo trip booking — where the user journey is linear and well-served by existing platforms — group trip planning lacks a coherent product that handles the full lifecycle.

Candidates often struggle to understand the full scope of coordination pain:

- How does a family with elders and toddlers plan differently from a college friend group?
- Why does the "organizer" always burn out?
- What makes passive members stop responding to messages?
- Why do budget conflicts only surface during the trip, never before?
- When exactly does group trip momentum die — and can a product prevent it?

Key Planning Challenges

Through observation of travel communities, group trip WhatsApp dynamics, and existing product gaps, several patterns emerge.

1. The Decision Bottleneck

Every group trip requires collective decisions on destination, dates, budget, and activities.

Current tools treat each decision independently, forcing groups to context-switch between:

- WhatsApp polls (for voting)
- Google Calendar / When2Meet (for date alignment)
- Google Sheets or mental math (for budget)
- Google Maps or travel blogs (for itinerary ideas)

The cost of each decision compounds. A group that takes 2 weeks to pick a destination often runs out of motivation before the itinerary is even started.

Research shows that larger groups plan months in advance, while solo travelers tend to book last minute — yet no current tool is designed for the long, multi-stakeholder decision cycle that groups require.

2. The Organizer Tax

In every group trip, one person absorbs the cognitive load of planning.

The organizer becomes the single point of failure for:

- Every logistics question ("what time is checkout?")
- Every coordination task ("who's booking the cab from the airport?")
- Every conflict resolution ("Rahul wants trekking but Meera wants the beach")
- Every budget conversation ("how much did dinner cost? Who paid?")

This labor is invisible and unrewarded. The organizer often has the worst trip experience because they're project-managing instead of relaxing.

According to EY's Indian travel research, there are now two distinct generational travel personas: younger travelers ("Gen ACE") who are adventurous and peer-influenced, and older travelers ("Gen LUX") who seek luxury and travel with family. In mixed groups, the organizer must reconcile these different expectations — an exhausting task with no tool support.

3. Unspoken Budget Misalignment

Budget is the #1 source of group trip friction, yet most groups never have an explicit budget conversation.

Budget realities in Indian domestic travel:

- **Domestic travel budgets** typically stay below ₹50,000 per person
- **International travel budgets** can exceed ₹1,00,000
- **Spending on international travel** from India is approximately 4x that of domestic travel
- **The gap between Tier I and Tier II city spending** is narrowing, but expectations still differ significantly within a single friend group

This misalignment surfaces in awkward moments — during restaurant choices, hotel tier selection, or activity planning — and is rarely resolved cleanly because no tool makes budgets transparent upfront.

4. Passive Participation

In any group of 6+, at least 2-3 members are passive. They don't vote on polls, don't respond to messages, and don't contribute to planning.

This isn't because they don't care. It's because:

- Current tools require too much effort (scrolling through 87 WhatsApp messages to find the poll)
- The UI isn't designed for one-tap participation
- Information is scattered — there's no single page that says "here's what's decided, here's what needs your input"
- Social dynamics discourage dissent ("whatever you all decide is fine")

70%+ of trip planning happens on mobile devices, often in fragmented 2-3 minute windows. Any product that requires more than 30 seconds of attention per interaction will lose passive members entirely.

5. No Single Source of Truth

Information is scattered across:

- WhatsApp messages (destination ideas, links, logistics)
- Google Docs (rough itinerary, if someone made one)
- Booking confirmation emails (hotel, flights, trains)
- Saved Instagram reels (restaurant recommendations, hidden gems)
- Someone's Notes app (the "real" plan that only the organizer knows)
- Splitwise (expenses, but only if everyone enters them)

There is no single place where any group member can go to see: where are we going, when, what's the plan each day, how much will it cost me, and what do I need to do?

Existing tools like Wanderlog come closest — offering collaborative itineraries, map views, and even budget tracking — but even Wanderlog's collaboration features are limited compared to what group planning actually requires (voting, budget transparency, real-time task assignment, passive-member nudging).

6. The Momentum Problem

Group trips have a natural energy curve:

1. High excitement when the idea is proposed ("Yes! Let's do Goa!")
2. Rapid decline as logistics set in (dates don't align, budget is unclear)
3. Death zone: 2-3 weeks of inactivity where nobody pushes the plan forward
4. Emergency sprint: someone panics, books everything last-minute, at higher prices
5. Post-trip: expense settling drags on for weeks

No current product is designed to maintain group momentum through this curve. The opportunity is to build a product with built-in urgency mechanisms (deadlines, nudges, progress visibility) that keeps the trip moving forward.

> **The Core Tension**
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> The ecosystem for group travel has plenty of booking tools but very little coordination infrastructure. Groups are surrounded by flight deals, hotel options, and Instagram inspiration — but what they lack is a shared system that guides them from "let's go somewhere" to "we're packed and ready." The opportunity is not another booking app. It is a group decision-making layer for travel.

Problem Statement

Groups of friends and families struggle to plan trips together due to fragmented tools, unequal planning burden, unspoken budget conflicts, and passive participation — leading to exhausted organizers, suboptimal trips, and sometimes damaged relationships.

Candidates often spend weeks trying to coordinate without clarity on:

- Where to go (decision paralysis across too many options)
- When everyone is free (calendar alignment across 5-10 people)
- What everyone can afford (budget transparency)
- What the plan is each day (itinerary ownership)
- Who owes whom afterward (expense settlement)

As a result, the group trip experience becomes unnecessarily stressful and unpredictable — for the organizer most of all.

Your Role as a Product Manager

You are the Product Manager responsible for designing and building a group & family travel planning platform.

Your goal is to create a product that reduces coordination friction and makes group trip planning collaborative, transparent, and enjoyable for everyone — not just the organizer.

You must focus on:

- **Understanding group planning behavior** — how do real groups of friends and families currently plan trips? What tools do they use? Where does the process break?
- **Identifying where the journey breaks down** — which moments create the most friction, conflict, or drop-off? Is it destination selection? Date alignment? Budget? Itinerary building?
- **Designing a product that distributes ownership** — how do you get everyone to participate, not just the organizer? How do you make participation effortless for passive members?
- **Building and shipping a working MVP** — a real, deployed product that a group of 5 friends could use to plan a trip this weekend.

Deliverables

Participants are expected to submit two components as part of this case study.

1. Product Requirement Document (PRD)

WHAT TO SUBMIT

Updated PRD Structure (Lean & Focused)

We've simplified the PRD so you spend more time building and less time writing. Your documentation should be a companion to what you built — not a novel.

1–2 pg	Discovery insights — who's the user, what did you learn?
1 pg	Problem prioritization — what problem and why this one?
1 pg	Proposed solution — simple explanation of your MVP
1 pg	Implementation plan — your build roadmap
2–3 pg	Instruction design — step-by-step build guide

2. Working MVP

Participants must also submit a working MVP of the proposed product. The MVP should demonstrate the core experience of the platform and show how the product solves the identified problem.

The MVP must be:

- **Deployed and accessible** — a live URL, not a localhost or Figma link
- **Functional end-to-end** — the core flow works with real data
- **Testable by a group** — 3+ people should be able to use it simultaneously
- **Mobile-friendly** — since 70%+ of trip planning happens on phones

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Submission Details

Next Saturday - April 4th 2026, 11:59PM

What to submit?

One pager Doc - Put names of your group members along with PRD link and Product link of each member separately - and anybody from the group can attach this Doc in LMS under sub group!

Both deliverables must be submitted by the announced deadline.

Participants should ensure that:

- The PRD document is clearly structured and references real user interviews
- The MVP link is accessible and functional
- Cross-group interviews are documented (mandatory — at least 1 person from each other group)
- All required sections are covered

A note on using AI tools

You are encouraged to use AI tools (Claude, Cursor, v0, etc.) to accelerate your work — for research synthesis, PRD drafting, code generation, and design iteration. However, the product thinking must be yours. AI can help you build faster; it cannot replace your judgment on what to build and why. The best case studies demonstrate original thinking grounded in real user evidence — not generated frameworks.